



WESTERN BALKANS FUND CONFERENCE OF THE MINISTERS OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS JOINT STATEMENT

Sarajevo, Bosnia and Herzegovina, 16 March 2018. The Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs of Western Balkans Fund, meeting in Sarajevo, Bosnia and Herzegovina, on 16 March 2018:

Highlighting the joint commitment to the principles of regional ownership and all-inclusiveness, as essential concepts for the successful and substantial implementation of regional cooperation agenda in the Western Balkans;

Noting with satisfaction that Western Balkans Fund became a reality and operational that started to accomplish its core objectives in supporting human mobility and strengthening people to people contacts in our region;

Underlining with appreciation the high interest for the WBF First Call for Regional Projects and considering the large number of applications as a clear sign of the readiness, maturity and willingness of our region to further cooperate and strengthen good neighbourly relations;

Considering very positively the high number of organizations involved as applicants in the Call, creating broad and vivid network that covers every angle of the region;

Appreciating the professional engagement of the WBF Secretariat throughout the process of the Call and for creating of the preliminary list of the winning projects for each Contracting Party;

Encouraging WBF Executive Director, WBF Secretariat and the WBF Committee of Senior Officials to carefully monitor the implementation of projects, as a direct contribution to the enhancement of people to people contacts in the region;

Emphasising our request to the European Union to positively consider the possibility to involve the WBF as a relevant partner, for the implementation of the Six Flagship Initiatives to support the transformation of Western Balkans;

1. We welcomed the Executive Director's Report on the First Call Regional Project Proposals and instructed the Committee of Senior Officials to establish the list of winning projects for the final approval by the Conference of Ministers of the WBF, by correspondence, by the end of March 2018.
2. We have agreed, in principle, following the statutory provisions of the WBF, Article 39, to double the Annual Contribution to the Western Balkans Fund budget (from 30000 EUR to 60000 EUR), towards the funding of projects, aiming to extend and strengthen this genuine and extremely relevant initiative of ours, subject to the conclusion of the internal procedures of each Contracting Party

We express our gratitude to the Host, Mr. Igor Crnadak, 2018 Chairman- in-Office of the WBF, for the hospitality and excellent arrangements made for the Meeting.

Done in Sarajevo, on 16 March 2018